Conference Review Form

Date: 20/08/2026	Document: EL2036	Conference: ICEEL 2026

Paper Title: Cultural dimensions in online learning: A Hofstede-moderated within-Asia synthesis of the Big Five and academic achievement, with a focused look at the Japanese context

	Poor	Fair	Good	Very Good	Outstanding
Integrity	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
Innovation	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐
Readability	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
Applicability	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐
Presentation and English	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
Match to Conference Topic	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒

***General Comments (no less than 150 words):**

This paper addresses a relevant and potentially useful question: whether a broad Asia/non-Asia moderator conceals country-level heterogeneity in the relationship between Big Five traits and online-learning achievement. The manuscript is clearly organized, transparent about the very small Asian evidence base, and commendably explicit that the k = 2 Hofstede regressions have zero residual degrees of freedom. The comparison of the Japanese studies also usefully highlights instrument heterogeneity. However, the central interpretation requires substantial revision. First, Hofstede and McCrae (2004) report country-level associations between national culture scores and aggregate personality means; these associations do not directly predict the sign of individual-level personality-achievement correlations within one country. The current 3-of-5 "direction-match" therefore risks a cross-level/ecological inference and should be framed as an exploratory theoretical comparison rather than a prediction test. Second, the two Japanese studies are not directly comparable in outcome or effect-size metric: Tokiwa contributes Spearman correlations with platform engagement/mastery measures, whereas Rivers contributes Pearson correlations with course grade. This weakens the claim that the repeated Neuroticism-positive direction is evidence about academic achievement. With only two Asian effect-size studies, the regression slopes are essentially two-country contrasts rather than meta-regression evidence. I recommend major revision to narrow the claims, separate engagement from achievement, and reposition the paper as an exploratory methodological/narrative synthesis. The topic is relevant to ICEEL and could become a useful cautionary contribution after these conceptual issues are addressed.

*Above 9 points will be eligible for the Best Article Award	Points (from 1.0-10.0)	Reject	Major Revision Required	Accept with Minor Revision	Accept
	7.8	☐	☐	☒	☐

Major Flaw	Line number (e.g. 17)	Clause/ Subclause (e.g. 3.1)	Paragraph/ Figure/ Table/ (e.g. Table 1)	Type of comment	Comments	Suggested Revision
1	No line nos. (p. 6)	4.4; 5.4	Table 4	Conceptual validity	HM04 country-level correlations between Hofstede dimensions and national mean Big Five scores are used to “predict” the sign of individual-level trait-outcome correlations in Japanese learners. This cross-level inference directly affects the central 3-of-5 direction-match claim.	Reframe Table 4 as exploratory correspondence, not a prediction/validation test; qualify “predicted” and “doubly predicted”; explicitly discuss the level-of-analysis mismatch. Ideally, support the mechanism with individual-level cultural measures or directly relevant evidence.
2	No line nos. (pp. 5-7)	4.2-4.4; 5.1-5.2	Tables 2-4	Methods / interpretation	The Japan comparison combines different constructs and statistics (Spearman ρ with platform engagement/mastery versus Pearson r with course grade), while the Hofstede meta-regression has only k = 2 and df_resid = 0. The slopes therefore add little statistical evidence beyond a two-country contrast.	Separate engagement and achievement outcomes and avoid treating directional agreement as replication of an achievement effect. Present the k = 2 slopes only as descriptive contrasts (or remove the meta-regression label) and substantially narrow the cultural/causal claims.